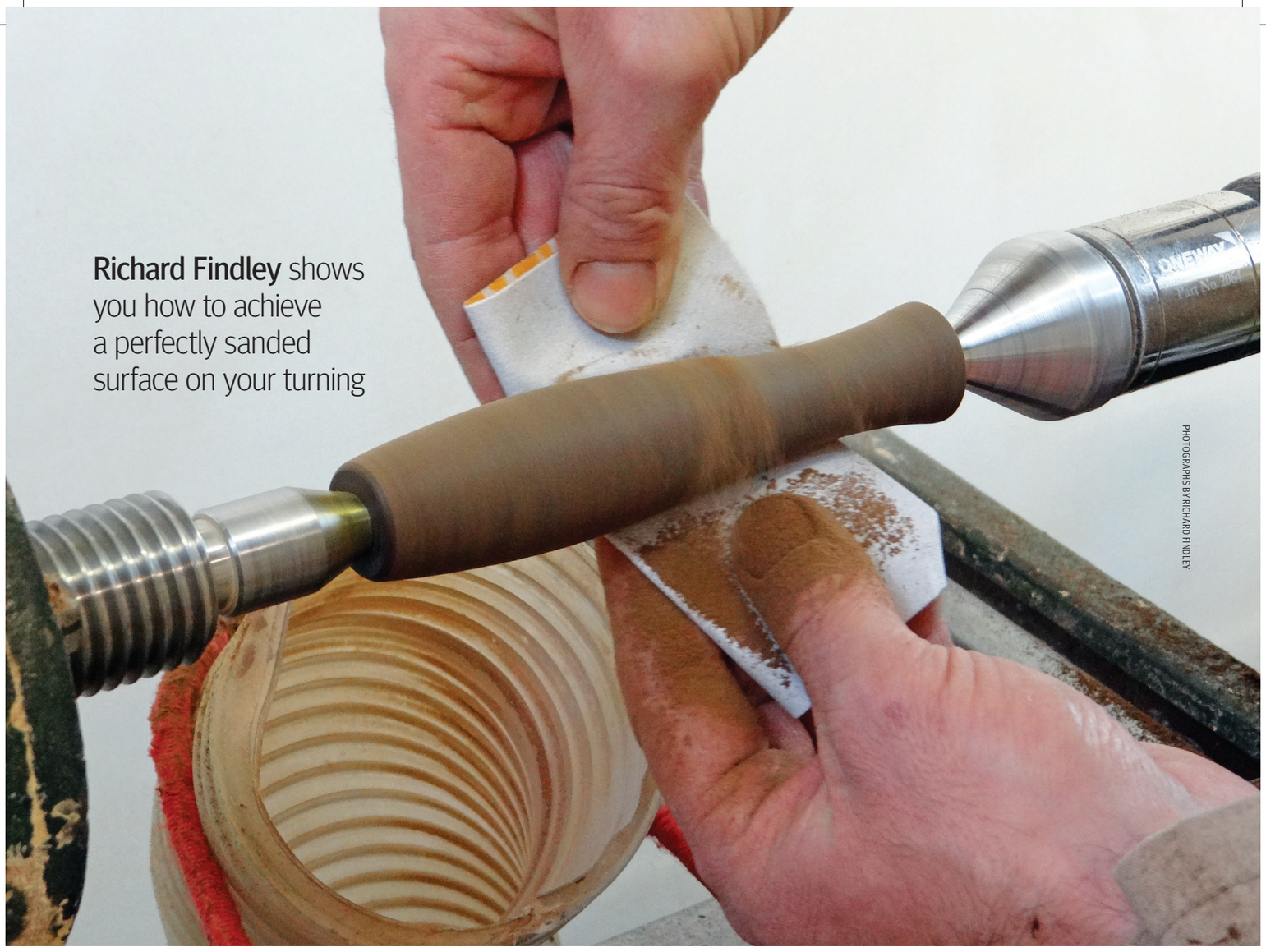

Richard Findley shows you how to achieve a perfectly sanded surface on your turning

PHOTOGRAPHS BY RICHARD FINDLEY

How to achieve a perfectly sanded surface

RICHARD FINDLEY

Richard is a registered UK professional woodturner living and working in Leicestershire. He discovered woodturning while working for his father as a joiner. He makes all kinds of work to commission, from replacement antique components, walking canes and stair spindles, to decorative bowls. It is the variety of work that he loves. He also offers demonstrations and a range of woodturning supplies.

richard@turnersworkshop.co.uk
www.turnersworkshop.co.uk
Follow on Instagram: richard_findley

You may look at this article and think 'Oh no, another article on sanding!' or 'I know how to sand, it's easy!', but I've seen so much turned work that could have been much better if it had been properly sanded, that I can only conclude that it isn't as easy as people think.

No one likes sanding. It's the last part of the job before the finish is applied and you get to see the grain 'pop' as you wipe the oil over the surface: the part most turners cite as their favourite bit. Sanding is dusty. If you power sand it is very dusty and noisy too. If you hand sand it wears away your finger prints and gets your fingers hot. It is no wonder that turners want to skip through this unpleasantness as quickly as possible and get on to the good part, but (and it's a big 'but') sanding is the last part of the turning process, the part that people will actually see the results of. This means if it's done badly, that is what people see. Don't think that applying the finish will hide poor sanding, because it won't; it will most likely highlight it. So in my opinion, sanding is one of the most important parts of the turning process. Don't get me wrong, all of the stuff before sanding needs doing properly and to the best of your ability too, but it is all for nothing if you don't sand properly.

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